



D. S. Brewer

Chapter Title: Tolkien: From Medieval Studies to Medievalist Fantasy

Book Title: Neomedievalism, Popular Culture, and the Academy

Book Subtitle: From Tolkien to Game of Thrones

Book Author(s): KellyAnn Fitzpatrick

Published by: Boydell & Brewer; D. S. Brewer

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctvktrx88.7>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



JSTOR

Boydell & Brewer and D. S. Brewer are collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to Neomedievalism, Popular Culture, and the Academy

Tolkien: From Medieval Studies to Medievalist Fantasy

AN INFORMAL DISCUSSION among twenty-first-century academics in the field of Anglo-Saxon, or Old English, studies revealed that almost half of them found their path to medieval studies through the writing of J. R. R. Tolkien.¹ Tolkien was himself a prominent philologist and Anglo-Saxon scholar who served, among other professional roles, as Rawlinson and Bosworth Professor of Anglo-Saxon at the University of Oxford. With such a scholarly pedigree, one might expect that Tolkien's draw to potential medievalists would be purely academic, and indeed some Anglo-Saxonists cite Tolkien's scholarly work as the impetus for their choice of career.² It is "early exposure" to Tolkien's fictional work, however, that is specifically credited as having lured so many Anglo-Saxonists to their current vocation.³ This is not surprising, as "Middle-earth," the fantastic world Tolkien constructs in *The Lord of the Rings*,⁴ *The Hobbit*, and *The*

¹ Jonathan Evans, "The Dragon Lore of Middle-Earth: Tolkien and Old English and Old Norse Tradition," in *J. R. R. Tolkien and His Literary Resonances: Views of Middle-Earth*, ed. George Clark and Daniel Timmons (Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 2000), 21.

² Andy Orchard, upon his appointment as Rawlinson and Bosworth Professor of Anglo-Saxon in 2013, noted that "Tolkien was one of the reasons I got into English ... because of his amazing lecture to the British Academy in 1936, 'Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics'. He was the first person really to think of *Beowulf* as a work of literature." See "Appointments – 30 May 2013," *Times Higher Education*, accessed May 15, 2015, <http://www.timeshighereducation.co.uk/news/people/appointments-30-may-2013/2004170>. article.

³ Evans, "The Dragon Lore of Middle-Earth," 21.

⁴ It should be noted that *The Lord of the Rings* was initially published as three separate books – *The Fellowship of the Ring* (1954), *The Two Towers* (1954), and *The Return of the King* (1955) – although Tolkien wrote and envisioned them

Silmarillion,⁵ has long been acknowledged as reflecting Tolkien's interest and professional training in the languages, literature, and culture of the European Middle Ages.⁶ At the same time, Tolkien's fiction is also read as firmly rooted in the events of the twentieth century. The Tolkien scholar Tom Shippey, for instance, locates Tolkien among a group of what he calls "traumatised authors, writing fantasy, but voicing in that fantasy the most pressing and immediately relevant issues of the whole monstrous twentieth century – questions of industrialised warfare, the origin of evil, the nature of humanity."⁷ Tolkien's medievalism, then, while shaped very much by his professional understanding of the Middle Ages, can also be seen as a means of critiquing the time and place in which he wrote.

As many Anglo-Saxonists have found their way to the Middle Ages through Tolkien's fantasy, Tolkien arguably found his way to them through William Morris, one of the best-known figures of the later part of the nineteenth-century British medieval revival. In what has become an oft-cited part of Tolkien lore, Tolkien biographer Humphrey Carpenter heralds Andrew Lang's *Red Fairy Book*,⁸ with its condensed version of William Morris's translation of the *Völsunga Saga*,⁹ as the impetus for

as a single text. Many later editions present the text in unified form, and all subsequent citations in this chapter refer to such an edition: J. R. R. Tolkien, *The Lord of the Rings*, 2nd ed. (Boston and New York: Houghton Mifflin, 1994).

⁵ While *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Hobbit* (1937), and *The Silmarillion* (1977) are his most widely known fictional works, Tolkien wrote extensively of Middle-earth up until his death in 1973. Much of this writing, including *The Silmarillion*, was published posthumously by Tolkien's son Christopher, who also served as editor. A complete list of Tolkien's publications up until 1998 can be found in Humphrey Carpenter, *J. R. R. Tolkien: A Biography* (1977; repr., Boston and New York: Houghton Mifflin, 2000), 266–75. For a continually updated list, see "Books by J. R. R. Tolkien," *The Tolkien Society*, accessed December 15, 2014, <http://www.tolkienociety.org/author/books-by-tolkien/>.

⁶ See Jane Chance, *Tolkien's Art: A Mythology for England*, rev ed. (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 2001); and Tom Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*, 3rd ed. (New York: Houghton Mifflin, 2003).

⁷ Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*, xvii.

⁸ Andrew Lang, ed., "The Story of Sigurd," in *The Red Fairy Book* (1890; repr., New York: Dover, 1966).

⁹ William Morris and Eiríkr Magnússon, trans., *Völsunga Saga: The Story of the Völsungs and Niblungs, with Certain Songs from the Elder Edda* (London: Ellis, 1870). Morris later adapted some of the events of the *Völsunga Saga* into a long, narrative poem: *The Story of Sigurd the Völsung and the Fall of the Niblung* (London: Ellis & White, 1877).

what Tolkien himself would later call his “profound desire” for dragons.¹⁰ In his excellent study of dragon-lore in Tolkien’s fiction, Jonathan Evans goes on to link this early exposure to the *Völsunga Saga*, which recounts the Norse myth in which Sigurd the Völsung slays the dragon Fafnir, to one of Tolkien’s earliest documented attempts at fiction. Evans cites a 1955 letter from Tolkien to W. H. Auden where he writes, “I first tried to write a story when I was about seven. It was about a dragon.”¹¹ When Tolkien writes to his future wife, Edith, in October of 1914, he describes how his short story in progress is modeled “somewhat on the lines of Morris’ romances with chunks of poetry in between.”¹²

The relationship between Tolkien and Morris’s work is extensive, and is covered in greater detail below, yet the anecdotes above offer a brief glimpse at how deeply Tolkien’s work is rooted in the nineteenth century as well as the twentieth. Indeed, all aspects of Tolkien’s medievalism – his professional training, his exposure to forms of non-academic medievalism, his use of the Middle Ages as contemporary critique – must also be understood as partly derived from what is commonly called the nineteenth-century British medieval revival. This resurgence of interest in the Middle Ages in everything from fiction to architecture to home décor affected not only culture and the arts, but also the ongoing professionalization of medieval studies that occurred throughout the nineteenth century, which resulted in what M. J. Toswell calls “the romanticizing eye of nineteenth-century medievalist scholarship and study that is the foundation of the medievalizing impulse in the contemporary world.”¹³ Accordingly, this chapter examines the relationship between Tolkien’s

¹⁰ Carpenter, *J. R. R. Tolkien: A Biography*, 30. The quotation from Tolkien comes from his 1947 essay “On Fairy-Stories,” based on a 1939 lecture at the University of St. Andrews and available in *The Monsters and the Critics and Other Essays*, ed. Christopher Tolkien (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1983), 135. Evans also recounts this story and, as regards Tolkien, cites Andrew Lang and William Morris as “his most immediate literary forebears” (“The Dragon Lore of Middle-Earth,” 22). For yet another analysis of the early link between Tolkien and Morris, see Andrew Lazo, “Gathered Round Northern Fires: The Imaginative Impact of the Kolbítar,” in *Tolkien and the Invention of Myth*, ed. Jane Chance (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 2004), 194–5.

¹¹ Evans, “The Dragon Lore of Middle-Earth,” 23. Evans cites Letter 163 from Humphrey Carpenter, ed., *The Letters of J. R. R. Tolkien* (1981; repr., Boston & New York: Houghton Mifflin, 2000), 214.

¹² Letter 1 in Carpenter, *The Letters of J. R. R. Tolkien*, 7.

¹³ M. J. Toswell, “The Tropes of Medievalism,” *Studies in Medievalism* XVII (2009): 74.

professional scholarship and popular fiction, and posits these aspects of Tolkien's medievalism as indebted to the nineteenth-century medieval revival. It further examines how Tolkien's medievalism has been read as a critique of twentieth-century events and concerns: another way in which Tolkien mirrors his nineteenth-century predecessors.

Tolkien and Medieval Studies

Tolkien's groundbreaking essay "*Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics*," which was originally delivered as a lecture to the British Academy in 1936, has since become a foundational text for twentieth-century medieval studies and remains frequently cited and anthologized to this day.¹⁴ In one of his opening passages, Tolkien famously takes aim at the body of scholarship surrounding the poem and the "critics" who have produced it:

I have, of course, read *The Beowulf*, as have most (but not all) of those who have criticized it. But I fear that ... I have not been a man so diligent in my special walk as duly to read all that has been printed on, or touching on, this poem. But I have read enough, I think, to venture the opinion that *Beowulfiana* is, while rich in many departments, especially poor in one. It is a poem poor in criticism, criticism that is directed to the understanding of the poem as a poem.¹⁵

Tolkien wryly implies that one need not read the poem in order to produce what passes as *Beowulf* criticism, yet his central argument that *Beowulf* should be read "as a poem" relies primarily on the vital assertion that medieval texts must be considered as works of art and not merely as historical or linguistic artifacts.

This assertion proved highly influential on medievalists who followed Tolkien, yet Tolkien's explanation of the critical approaches that had until that point prevailed in *Beowulf* criticism provides a fascinating look at the state of professional medieval studies in the early half of the twentieth century. He writes:

¹⁴ For a full literary history of the lecture and essay, see Michael D. C. Drout, ed., *Beowulf and the Critics by J. R. R. Tolkien*, 2nd ed. (Tempe, AZ: ACMRS, 2011).

¹⁵ J. R. R. Tolkien, "*Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics*," in Christopher Tolkien, ed., *The Monsters and the Critics and Other Essays* (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1983), 5.

As it set out upon its adventures among the modern scholars, *Beowulf* was christened by Wanley Poesis – *Poesios Anglo-Saxonicae egregium exemplum*. But the fairy godmother later invited to superintend its fortunes was Historia. And she brought with her Philologia, Mythologia, Archaeologia, and Laographia. Excellent ladies. But where was the child's name-sake? Poesis was usually forgotten.¹⁶

History, philology, mythology, archaeology, laography (folklore): the list of disciplinary approaches that Tolkien contrasts with poetry, allegorized as they are, is telling: excluding folklore, all are approaches with long academic pedigrees that preceded the professionalization of medieval studies that occurred in the nineteenth century.

While the early twentieth century saw the creation of formal centers that institutionalized medieval studies as an interdisciplinary pursuit,¹⁷ many of the related disciplines have institutional histories that stretch back to the Middle Ages themselves, when the university as we know it came into being. Theology and liberal arts were courses of study available in the medieval university proper, while fields such as philology and archeology developed later, in part due to a Renaissance interest in Greece and Rome.¹⁸ By the late seventeenth century European scholars began pursuing these disciplines with a focus on the subject matter of the Middle Ages;¹⁹ the eighteenth century saw the creation of institutional appointments in areas that we now associate specifically with medieval studies. Tolkien's post at Oxford, for instance, the Rawlinson and Bosworth Professor of Anglo-Saxon, was established in 1795. The creation of similar high-profile positions throughout the nineteenth century, such

¹⁶ Ibid., 6.

¹⁷ The Medieval Institute at the University of Notre Dame, for instance, was formed in 1946; similar interdisciplinary programs were founded throughout the 1960s at various universities in North America and Europe. For more on the institutionalization of medieval studies as an academic discipline, see Chapter 1, pp. 5–8.

¹⁸ As I note in my introduction, neoclassical impulses in part led to the constitution of the “Middle Age” as a means of aligning the “Modern” with the “Classical” civilizations of Greece and Rome.

¹⁹ For an excellent history of scholars of medieval subject matter, see Helen Damico et al., eds., *Medieval Scholarship: Biographical Studies in the Formation of a Discipline*, 3 vols. (New York: Garland, 1995–2000). I take my dating of the late seventeenth century from Damico's inclusion (with which I agree) of both Jean Bolland (1596–1665), founding author of the *Acta Sanctorum*, and Jean Mabillon (1632–1707), considered the founder of the field of paleography.

as the Elrington and Bosworth Professor of Anglo-Saxon at Cambridge in 1878, indicates the progressively professionalized field of specifically medieval scholarship.

The professionalization of medieval studies in the nineteenth century relied in no small part on the increasing availability of artifacts from the Middle Ages. In Britain, many such artifacts were discovered and collected through the efforts of antiquaries who made the recovery, study, and preservation of antiquities, or artifacts, their business. As D. R. Woolf notes, the “antiquarian impulse” in Britain can be traced back as early as 1500, when antiquaries functioned as “the finest sort of critical, learned philologist.”²⁰ As a general interest in gathering objects from the past drove the formation of various antiquarian movements and societies, and this interest garnered the participation of wealthy and often untrained members, by 1700 the word antiquary, according to Woolf, “had become widely synonymous with pedantry, tedious conversation, a morbid fascination with rot and decay, and an undisciplined love of the old – precisely the pejorative image conjured up by the more modern ‘antiquarian.’”²¹ Antiquarians thereby became one of the groups against whom trained scholars defined themselves, although a number of antiquarians were as learned as their formally trained scholarly counterparts, especially in fields that had little formal precedent.

Furthermore, the products of antiquarian labor, which included but were not limited to artifacts from the Middle Ages, often became the basis of scholarly research. As Woolf points out, the “spadework” of antiquaries, which turned up countless manuscripts, documents, coins, and other objects, made it possible for modern scholars to build careers out of studying the past without ever having held such an artifact in their hands. *Beowulf*, for instance, the cornerstone of Anglo-Saxon studies on which Tolkien based his famous lecture, was recovered and preserved through the efforts of Sir Robert Cotton, the late-seventeenth/early-eighteenth-century antiquary whose collection became a founding component of the British Museum.²² Notably, the survival of specifically medieval English artifacts can be attributed in part to those antiquaries

²⁰ D. R. Woolf, “Dawn of the Artifact: The Antiquarian Impulse in England, 1500–1730,” *Studies in Medievalism* IV (1992): 27.

²¹ Ibid.

²² *Beowulf* has been found in written form in a single manuscript, Cotton Vitellius A.xv, dating from c. 1000 CE. Although almost lost in a fire that destroyed parts of the manuscript, the poem represents roughly 10 percent of the Anglo-Saxon literary corpus.

who braved accusations of “popery” throughout the English Reformation and Civil War in order to preserve medieval artifacts and texts.²³

The availability of texts was further bolstered by the formation of various text societies in the early nineteenth century. As Clare Simmons notes, “The Camden Society is a good example of a growing interest in historical publishing after the founding of the Roxburghe club in 1814. Formed in 1838 to publish documents illustrative of English history, it provided a new window on the medieval world.”²⁴ Although the Roxburghe club in particular began as an exclusive club whereby owners of antiquities would meet to share them, it marked the beginning of formal means by which medieval texts could be accessed other than through direct requests to their owners. The more widespread publication project of the Camden Society made access to texts even less exclusive, so that scholars had no longer to rely on knowing someone who would grant them access to their personal collection. Its example was followed by other groups, such as the Early English Text Society (1864), which produces editions to this day.

As published texts became more widely available, scholars relied more on methodology as a means of distinguishing themselves from casual readers, publishers, and collectors. As Lee Patterson notes, philology, the field with which Tolkien identified, in particular established an affinity for methodology that was pitted against the perceived lack of rigor of antiquarianism.²⁵ Patterson cites scholars such as Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm as adhering to methodology in the absence of consistent university appointments. Perhaps best remembered now for their *Kinder- und Hausmärchen*, the Grimms blended their recovery and recording of folklore with a highly regimented and documented dissection and study of the languages in which they were conveyed: a fact that lent validity to their work even when they were between university appointments.

²³ See Woolf, “The Dawn of the Artifact,” 11–16. I am indebted to the art historian Rachel Dressler for kindly pointing me to the antiquarian and medieval historian William Dugdale, best known for *The Antiquities of Warwickshire* (1656), as a prime example of antiquaries who made the preservation of medieval artifacts their project as a reaction to the destructive impulses of the Puritan government of the Commonwealth towards any object seen as related to Catholicism.

²⁴ Clare Simmons, introduction to *Medievalism and the Quest for the “Real” Middle Ages* (London and Portland, OR: Frank Cass, 2001), 9.

²⁵ Lee Patterson, *Negotiating the Past: The Historical Understanding of Medieval Literature* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1987), 12–13.

In spite of its regimented methodologies, the actual subject matter of philology can be difficult to quantify outside of a general affiliation with language, literature, and the history of one or both. Tom Shippey has commented on the “elusive nature” of philology and points to an academic schism in Tolkien’s time between “lit & lang”: a schism that Tolkien saw as artificially separating the study of languages from literature.²⁶ As far as Tolkien’s own knowledge of languages goes, as David Lyle Jeffrey notes, “He had extensive knowledge of the Romance languages and of Anglo-Saxon, Welsh, Finnish, Old Norse, Old Icelandic, German (from Old High German to the modern), Gothic, Old Friesian, Afrikaans, and Dutch.”²⁷ In short, Tolkien’s comprehension of languages was wide-ranging and prolific, even for a philologist. As Shippey suggests, by Tolkien’s time antiquarianism had fallen out of vogue, yet, as Tolkien’s elision of “The Monsters” and “The Critics” in his lecture suggests, the not necessarily learned “critic” now served as one of the foils against whom a philologist such as Tolkien might define himself, especially in terms of an ability to uncover an authentic medieval past through the tools of his profession. As Shippey notes of the two fields, “An associated difference was that philologists were more likely than critics to believe in what one might call ‘the reality of history.’”²⁸

The concept of history as constituting a lost truth that could be uncovered – a concept that widely fell out of favor in the latter part of the twentieth century – was foundational to nineteenth-century medieval studies. In his excellent account of the historiography of the Middle Ages from the Enlightenment through the end of the twentieth century, Walter Kudrycz outlines how the work of Leopold van Ranke was particularly influential on the path of medieval studies.²⁹ Ranke crystallized a positivist idea of a “scientific history” that could recount the past “as it really was” without subjective intrusion. Although Ranke’s historiographical concepts have since been heavily critiqued, they were nonetheless extremely influential on historians and scholars in related fields.³⁰ As Clare Simmons notes:

²⁶ Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*, 6–13.

²⁷ David Lyle Jeffrey, “Tolkien as Philologist,” in *Tolkien and the Invention of Myth*, ed. Jane Chance (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 2004), 62.

²⁸ Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*, 29.

²⁹ Walter Kudrycz, *The Historical Present: Medievalism and Modernity* (London and New York: Continuum Books, 2011), 105–40.

³⁰ For critique, see Hayden White, *Metahistory: The Historical Imagination in Nineteenth-Century Fiction* (1973; repr. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins, 1987).

Within medieval studies, a number of key questions recur, including the quest for origins; the relationship between religion and nationalism; and the model of an ordered, idyllic society. Yet although all of these present a challenge to the notion of an “authentic” Middle Ages, in the later nineteenth and early twentieth century, the quest for answers to these questions becomes subordinated to a desire for the real, the historical, the documented.³¹

Ergo, in the nineteenth century and during the years that formed Tolkien's identity as a medievalist, the actuality of the Middle Ages was accepted as both real and recoverable through objective means.

In retrospect, the reality of the Middle Ages became a powerful tool for justifying contemporary positions. As Lee Patterson observes:

After all, much of the nineteenth-century historicism had been motivated by a desire to use the past, and specifically the medieval past, to prescribe a future, whether it was the restoration of the ancien regime in France, to the reunification of Germany, or the dismantling of industrial techniques of labor management in England.³²

This made the matter of the Middle Ages important collateral, and one from which medieval studies further benefitted. As Clare Simmons has demonstrated, the study of Anglo-Saxon in particular was bolstered throughout the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries in England by a growing association of Anglo-Saxon history and culture with English nationalism. This rhetoric constructed post-invasion Norman influences as a contrast to Anglo-Saxon culture; “Norman” was negatively associated with modern France, an association that only strengthened through the Napoleonic wars and into the Victorian era.³³

Medievalism and the Medieval Revival

The use of the Middle Ages for one rhetorical bent or another was not limited to medieval scholars, as reproducing the Middle Ages became a tool for various political movements and statements made outside

³¹ Simmons, *Medievalism and the Quest for the “Real” Middle Ages*, 1–2.

³² Patterson, *Negotiating the Past*, 16.

³³ See Clare A. Simmons, *Reversing the Conquest: History and Myth in Nineteenth-Century Literature* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 1990); and her “Iron-Worded Proof: Victorian Identity and the Old English Language,” *Studies in Medievalism* IV (1992): 202–14.

the realm of scholarship. Although medieval studies excluded forms of popular medievalism as part of its disciplinary constitution, the rhetorical positioning of the Middle Ages was especially prevalent in the various forms of literary, artistic, and cultural medievalism that characterized the nineteenth-century medieval revival.³⁴ Lee Paterson suggests that these instances of medievalism can be organized as follows:

Popular medievalism in England divided into two major schools or attitudes, the most powerful representing the Middle Ages as universalist, institutional, and deeply conservative. Bishops Hurd and Percy, Sir Walter Scott, Coleridge and Wordsworth, Southey, Carlyle, Kenhelm Henry Digby, Disraeli and the Young Englanders – these enthusiasts of things medieval celebrated the Middle Ages as a time when a harmonious society was held together by bonds of common faith and unquestioned social order ...

In opposition to this conservative model the nineteenth century also saw the development of the Middle Ages as pluralist, primitivist, and above all else, individualist. This was the view made popular by Ruskin and Morris and, to a lesser extent, the Pre-Raphaelites For Ruskin and Morris, and for others like them, the Middle Ages were valuable not because of their powerful institutions of control and order but in spite of them.³⁵

A comprehensive review of both “schools” and their relationship to each other has already been ably executed by scholars in medievalism studies and is outside the scope of this book.³⁶ I instead read Walter Scott and William Morris as representative exempla of conservative and progressive

³⁴ For an excellent and succinct summary of the exclusionary practices of medieval studies (and the consequences of these practices), see Kathleen Biddick, *The Shock of Medievalism* (Durham, NC, and London: Duke University Press, 1998), 1–2.

³⁵ Patterson, *Negotiating the Past*, 9–11.

³⁶ See Alice Chandler, *A Dream of Order: The Medieval Ideal in Nineteenth-Century Literature* (London: Routledge, 1970). Chandler’s study provides a broad yet detailed overview of the nineteenth-century medieval revival and its contributing antecedents. As an excellent complement, Mark Girouard covers the same period with a focus on the role of chivalry in *The Return to Camelot: Chivalry and the English Gentleman* (New Haven, CT, and London: Yale University Press, 1981). For a more recent review of nineteenth-century medievalism, see Michael Alexander, *Medievalism: The Middle Ages in Modern England* (New Haven, CT, and London: Yale University Press, 2007).

medievalism, respectively; both have been selected as key figures of the medieval revival and because they both proved influential on Tolkien.

As Alice Chandler observes, it is tempting to view the work of Walter Scott as the source of renewed popular interest in the Middle Ages that constituted the nineteenth-century medieval revival; and yet, as this chapter has shown and Chandler cautions, "Quite as much as Scott's poems and novels had created much of the medievalism that followed, they were themselves the product of more than two centuries' investigation of the feudal past."³⁷ Indeed, some of the earliest and most famous manifestations of non-scholarly medievalism date to Henry VII's assumption of Arthurian lineage as a means of legitimating a crown won on the battlefield, and his son Henry VIII's restyling of the Winchester "Round Table" in Tudor colors.³⁸ Coinciding with the interest in gathering and studying objects from the past that drove various antiquarian movements and text societies, and bolstered by a renewed interest in and reproduction of Gothic architecture throughout the eighteenth century,³⁹ popular interest in the Middle Ages arguably never died out; it is therefore common to hear medievalism of the nineteenth century characterized as a product of "survival and revival" by later writers.⁴⁰

Initially aspiring to the then more respected art of poetry, Scott incorporated medieval themes into his work and had success with long narrative poems such as *Marmion* and the *Lay of the Last Minstrel*. The growing genre of the novel proved more lucrative, however, and Scott's highly detailed reimagining of historic events and settings popularized

³⁷ Chandler, *A Dream of Order*, 12.

³⁸ Debra N. Mancoff, *The Return of King Arthur: The Legend through Victorian Eyes* (New York: Harry N. Abrams, 1995), 20. Initial construction of the Winchester Round Table is attributed to Edward I, who reigned England from 1272 to 1307. Like Henry VII and Henry VIII, Edward used Arthurian legend, which drew on an earlier period in English history and legend, to help legitimize and glorify his own reign. Medievalism, therefore, may be seen as a reinvention of earlier forms of rhetoric and propaganda (with some reinventions dating from the Middle Ages themselves) that make use of established tropes, legend, and traditions. Notably, the intersections of medievalism and Arthurian legend have produced many instances of literary medievalism aimed at royal patrons, such as Spenser's *The Faerie Queene* (dedicated to Elizabeth I) and Tennyson's *Idylls of the King* (dedicated to Albert, the Prince Consort).

³⁹ See Alexander, *Medievalism*, 1–23.

⁴⁰ See Girouard, *The Return to Camelot*, 15–28; see also David Matthews, "From Mediaeval to Mediaevalism: A New Semantic History," *The Review of English Studies* 62 (2011): 695–715.

the genre that we now call the “historical novel.” While most of his written work displays a preoccupation with the past, whether the Scottish Rebellion of the previous century in his *Waverly* novels or the even more romanticized past of his earlier poetic works, Scott’s most successful and enduring work has proven to be *Ivanhoe*, published in 1819. This story of a fictional dispossessed Saxon knight set among the “historical” events of Richard I and the aftermath of the Crusades became an influential image of the Middle Ages for a number of readers, writers, and politicians in the decades to come. Arguably, one of the more appealing aspects of *Ivanhoe* to Scott’s contemporaries was its idealization of chivalry, which is associated most closely with the Saxon *Ivanhoe*. This idealization can be traced to Scott’s non-fiction work. In his 1818 “Essay on Chivalry,” Scott outlines the behavior and characteristics of the medieval knight, and also contemplates the relationship of the social standing of these knights to his own contemporary social strata. He writes:

All, too, in the rank and station of gentlemen, are forcibly called upon to remember, that they must resent the imputation of a voluntary falsehood as the most gross injury; and that the rights of the weaker sex demand protection from every one who would hold a good character in society. In short, from the wild and overstrained courtesies of chivalry has been derived our present system of manners.⁴¹

Scott’s representation of medieval chivalry in *Ivanhoe*, then, is a vivid construction of what Scott saw as the roots of proper British society of the nineteenth century.

As Mark Girouard has argued, Scott’s attempt to capture the chivalrous way of life through his writing is reflected in his attempts to construct a particular image of his own life as a gentleman of leisure in spite of his need to write to earn a living.⁴² Pointedly, part of this image involved a carefully constructed medieval-inspired setting; in 1811 Scott commissioned the construction of Abbotsford, a house built in the “Gothic” style that became popular in the previous century. As Girouard notes, the association between the rules that governed the aristocratic institutions of chivalry and the manners expected of the nineteenth-century British gentleman made medievalism an ideal tool for conservative Tory politics, a relationship perhaps best indicated by the dominant Tory attend-

⁴¹ Walter Scott, “Essay on Chivalry,” 1818. Reprinted in *Essays on Chivalry, Romance and Drama* (London: Frederick Warne, 1887), 25.

⁴² Girouard, *The Return to Camelot*, 38.

ance of the Eglinton Tournament in 1839.⁴³ The Eglinton Tournament, which is often read as inspired by the tournament at Ashby from Scott's *Ivanhoe*, was planned as a full-on joust. Complete with members of the aristocracy in armor and a Queen of Love and Beauty, the tournament was mostly rained out; nonetheless, the tournament's appeal to an earlier age of chivalry – albeit most likely as interpreted by Walter Scott – is apparent, especially when considered in light of contemporary events. As indicated by the Reform Act of 1832, which extended voting rights to those who did not own land, the industrial development of Britain increasingly removed economic and political power from the landed aristocracy. Similar to Scott's earlier "Essay on Chivalry," which tied the contemporary aristocracy to a historically powerful feudal nobility, Thomas Carlyle's 1843 treatise *Past and Present* worked to naturalize these identities so that they might withstand their dislocation by increasingly powerful bourgeois capitalists.⁴⁴ By insisting that land and bloodlines were still the dominant criteria by which society should be ordered, and that the aristocracy had a responsibility to lead the nation, such tracts attempted in vain to maintain the status quo in an ever-evolving mode of capitalist production.

Scott's medievaesque pursuits were not, however, entirely tied up in conservative politics. Scott himself was an avid fan of Chaucer, and, as David Matthews indicates, his 1804 edition of *Sir Tristram* – where Scott, in a show of Scottish nationalism, argues for a Scottish origin of the text – can be seen as one of the earliest contributions towards the establishment of Middle English studies.⁴⁵ Arguably, in addition to contributing to a widespread revival of interest in the Middle Ages, Scott's most significant contribution to later ages was the popularization of the historical novel. As Alice Chandler observes, Scott's employment of the historical novel capitalized on a growing popular fascination with the past: "Scott brought this interest to a focus by creating a completely believable medieval world, which he portrayed so vividly and attractively that many of his readers took it for historical truth rather than historical fiction."

⁴³ Ibid., 94.

⁴⁴ Alice Chandler complicates Carlyle's conservative medievalism in "Carlyle and the Medievalism of the North," in *Medievalism in the Modern World: Essays in Honor of Leslie J. Workman*, ed. Richard Utz and Tom Shippey (Turnhout, Belgium: Brepols, 1998), 173–91.

⁴⁵ David Matthews, "'Quaint Inglis': Walter Scott and the Rise of Middle English Studies," *Studies in Medievalism* VII (1996): 46.

Furthermore, his attention to detail led his readers to mistake his fictionalized reproduction of history for fact.⁴⁶

As John Hunter has argued, Scott's popularization of the historical novel genre was highly influential on Tolkien. Hunter points in particular to the detailed mythology and history that Tolkien creates around *The Lord of the Rings* and *The Hobbit*, a history that is clear through the appendices of *The Lord of the Rings* and which would be later expanded and solidified in *The Silmarillion*. Hunter states of Tolkien, "The history that this novel records is imagined rather than factual, but this has not in any way distracted readers from the linguistic and cultural 'authenticity' of Tolkien's world or the pleasures of historical fiction that it provides."⁴⁷ This claim fits with Tolkien's own description of his works as a matter of transcribing "found" events. In a letter to his publisher Tolkien famously writes of Middle-earth, "Always I had the sense of recording what was already 'there,' somewhere: not of 'inventing.'"⁴⁸ That the Middle-earth that Tolkien "found" subscribes to a somewhat conservative adaptation of the Middle Ages is also arguably attributable to Scott's mark on the medieval revival: that Aragorn, the ranger who is eventually crowned King of Gondor, is hereditarily born to the position would fit nicely with Scott's conservatively and mediievally tinged view of the world.

Tolkien was also heavily influenced by the products of the more activist, or progressive, side of the nineteenth-century medieval revival; this influence is most apparent via William Morris, the late nineteenth-century polymath. By all accounts, at a young age Morris already displayed a precocious propensity for both reading and history: a disposition that led him straight to the works of Walter Scott. As the Morris biographer Fiona MacCarthy recounts, "At the age of four the infant William Morris was deep in the Waverly novels, and he claimed that by the time he was seven he had read the entire *œuvre* of Walter Scott Scott, he used to say, meant more to him than Shakespeare."⁴⁹ Morris's most direct entry into the activity of the medieval revival, however, came through his interaction with the Pre-Raphaelites.

⁴⁶ Alice Chandler, *A Dream of Order*, 12.

⁴⁷ John Hunter, "The Reanimation of Antiquity and the Resistance to History: Macpherson–Scott–Tolkien," in *Tolkien's Modern Middle Ages*, ed. Jane Chance and Alfred K. Siewers (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 62.

⁴⁸ Letter 131 in Carpenter, *The Letters of J. R. R. Tolkien*, 145.

⁴⁹ Fiona MacCarthy, *William Morris: A Life for Our Time* (New York: Knopf, 1995), 5–6.

The Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood officially formed in 1848 in common rebellion against the artistic techniques taught at the Royal Academy in the middle of the nineteenth century, which was strictly based in the work of the Italian Renaissance painters Raphael and Michelangelo. The Pre-Raphaelites sought a return to the artistic values demonstrated in paintings produced prior to Raphael – those of an earlier medieval period – ergo the name “Pre-Raphaelite” Brotherhood. In breaking away from the Academy, the Pre-Raphaelites established the concept of “truth to nature” as one of their guiding precepts. As art historian Tim Barringer notes, this precept is directly attributed to the writing of John Ruskin, the art critic best known for *The Seven Lamps of Architecture*, *The Stones of Venice*, and most relevant in this context, *Modern Painters*, where Ruskin tasks artists to “go to nature” rather than “ape the execution of the masters.”⁵⁰ The Pre-Raphaelites were thus committed to capturing images as truthful to “reality” as they could. In addition to viewing the precept of “truth to nature” as a specifically medieval aesthetic, the group tended to incorporate subject matter and narratives inspired by the Middle Ages into their work, although not all Pre-Raphaelite work focuses on medieval themes. The result: when painting a scene out of medieval legend or myth, the Pre-Raphaelites strove to paint it as close to nature as possible, or as close to nature as the event would have been if it had actually happened.

John Everett Millais provides one of the clearest examples of this principle in his 1852 painting *Ophelia*.⁵¹ The subject of Millais’ painting is the character of Ophelia from Shakespeare’s mediievally set tragedy *Hamlet*. Millais captures Ophelia just at the moment before she is pulled down under the water, as she floats surrounded by flowers with her face just above the surface. In painting this image, Millais intensively studied models for the flowers and foliage that surround Ophelia so as to capture

⁵⁰ Tim Barringer, *Reading the Pre-Raphaelites*, rev. ed. (London: Yale University Press, 2012), 62. Barringer cites volume 1 of Ruskin’s *Modern Painters* (1843).

⁵¹ Millais is particularly interesting in that his work includes portraits of three of the key figures associated with the phenomena of the medieval revival: Ruskin (whose wife, Effie, left Ruskin for Millais), Tennyson (whose poems he painted), and Carlyle. Millais’ work, then, points to not only a fascination with an idealized Middle Ages, but also a fascination with the ongoing process of the medieval revival itself. One could argue that the appeal of the Middle Ages for Millais lies not only in the medieval, but also in the process of and figures associated with representing the medieval to the nineteenth century.

both with botanical accuracy. In addition, the flowers he chose were either listed in Shakespeare's play or else included for particular symbolic meaning.⁵² In painting the figure of Ophelia, Millais had his model (Elizabeth Siddall, who would later marry his fellow Pre-Raphaelite Dante Gabriel Rossetti), lie in a bathtub wearing Ophelia's diaphanous blue dress. Millais engineered all of this in order to paint a "realistic" representation of the fictional medieval character of Ophelia, all in the name of returning to a medieval style of art that had allegedly existed before the artificial influences of the Renaissance.

Morris was drawn into what is often called the "second wave" of the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood, which primarily revolved around Morris himself, founding member Dante Gabriel Rossetti, and Edmund Burne-Jones.⁵³ Although Morris would later establish a reputation for the stained glass, wallpaper, and fabric designs he developed for the various incarnations of his design firm, Morris & Co., he was not an accomplished painter. His one known surviving painting, known alternately as *Queen Guinevere* and *La Belle Iseult* (1858), represents the efforts of Dante Gabriel Rossetti attempting to teach Morris how to paint.⁵⁴

Although not a prolific painter, Morris was, during his initial interactions with the Pre-Raphaelites, already an established poet, as demonstrated by the 1858 publication of *The Defence of Guinevere, and Other Poems*. Some critics have argued that Morris's earlier works point to an aesthetic medievalism that privileges a love of beauty for beauty's sake,

⁵² For an excellent analysis of the plant life in the painting, see Barringer, *Reading the Pre-Raphaelites*, 63–5.

⁵³ The "first wave" of the Pre-Raphaelite Brotherhood, which formally lasted from 1848 to 1853, included Rossetti, his brother William Michael Rossetti, Millais, William Holman Hunt, James Collinson, and Thomas Woolner. Although the group focused primarily on painting, Woolner was a sculptor and other members, such as W. M. Rossetti, were primarily writers.

⁵⁴ Rachel Barnes, *The Pre-Raphaelites and Their World* (London: Tate Gallery Publishing, 1998), 94. See also MacCarthy, *William Morris: A Life for Our Time*, 115–34, which recounts Morris's effort to learn to paint in what he considered to be the Pre-Raphaelite style: an effort driven in part by Rossetti, who, as MacCarthy notes, "believed anyone could be a painter" (115). MacCarthy also provides biographical information surrounding the composition of *Queen Guinevere / La Belle Iseult*, including Morris's relationship with Jane Burden, his future wife and the model for Guinevere/Iseult. That Burden would later model for Rossetti – with whom she conducted a long-running affair – helps illustrate the somewhat tangled and incestuous nature of the Pre-Raphaelites' social and artistic circle.

and, indeed, while his poetic works on Arthurian themes performed certain social critiques, Morris's early medievalism does suggest a form of escapism.⁵⁵ The Red House, which Morris commissioned from the architect Phillip Webb in 1859, for instance, constitutes an effort to reproduce a medieval space into which one could temporarily escape from the overly busy and crowded architecture and décor of mid-Victorian England. Built, according to Morris, in a thirteenth-century style, the house included a secondary side porch called "Pilgrim's Rest": a clear allusion to the carefully chosen location of the house on the route that Chaucer's pilgrims would have taken on their way to Canterbury.⁵⁶

It would be shortsighted, however, to reduce Morris's early works to mere aesthetics or escapism. Morris was also deeply interested in the working of medieval craftsmen and tradesmen, and therefore evidenced as much concern for the construction and materials of his Red House as for the finished product. Morris's interest in medieval craftsmanship led to his founding of Morris & Co., which produced cleanly designed and hand-crafted furniture and interior decorations based on medieval designs; while Morris hoped to make these products affordable alternatives to mass-produced items of more modern design, ironically, they cost far more than most people could afford.

Morris's later writing, influenced by interaction with the socialist movement, shows a clearly altered understanding of the revolutionary capacity of representations of the Middle Ages.⁵⁷ Like Scott and his conservative contemporaries, Morris mourned the rise of the industrial revolution and the loss of a pastoral and structured society. However, while Scott's nostalgia was for the paternal rule of an aristocracy, Morris looked to the Middle Ages as a time of ideal working conditions for craftsmen and artisans, coupled with a revolutionary spirit that eventually overturned the more oppressive aspects of feudalism. In *The Dream of John Ball* (1888), Morris's Narrator dreams of a conversation with an

⁵⁵ See Bradley J. MacDonald, *William Morris and the Aesthetic Constitution of Politics* (Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 1999).

⁵⁶ Marcus Waithe, *William Morris's Utopia of Strangers: Victorian Medievalism and the Ideal of Hospitality* (Cambridge: D. S. Brewer, 2006), 43. See also the entirety of Waithe's section on "The Pilgrim's Rest: Privacy, Property and the Structures of Welcome in William Morris's Red House" (34–50).

⁵⁷ Morris joined the Social Democratic Federation in 1883, is known to have read *Das Kapital* "in its French translation," and "made ample use of Marx's historical chapters both in his lectures and his two visionary novels, *A Dream of John Ball* and *News from Nowhere*." See Chandler, *A Dream of Order*, 219.

English priest who would be hanged for inspiring the Peasant's Revolt of 1381, a dream from which he wakes to contemplate the imperfect results of this revolt evident in his own nineteenth-century conditions.⁵⁸ Morris's most revolutionary-minded work of fiction, however, is his *News from Nowhere* (1890).

Morris's utopia of Nowhere portrays an economically advanced future that has culturally reverted to the fashions and artistry of the Middle Ages. Morris writes, though the eyes of Christopher Guest, his time-travelling narrator from the nineteenth century, "Their dress was somewhat between that of the ancient classical costume and the simpler forms of the fourteenth-century garments, though it was clearly not an imitation of either."⁵⁹ Economically and socially, the residents of Nowhere have established a system that is clearly founded in socialism, as society functions with each member willingly performing labor according to his or her own inclination.

Many critics, including Morris himself, have pointed out an overall child-like quality of Nowhere society. Michael Holzman argues that children play an important role in Morris's layout of Nowhere in that they are the first to introduce Guest to the economic workings of Nowhere society. Of an incident in which Guest receives tobacco from a store run by children Holzman writes:

It is not by chance that these first shopkeepers are children; it is an indication that in a quite significant way all the inhabitants in Morris's dream-adventure enjoy a mode of existence only conceivable in Morris's everyday world in terms of childhood; specifically, in terms of the school holidays of Morris's own comfortable childhood. To show people who are not reduced to functions of the commercial economy, the only example available to

⁵⁸ Alice Chandler attributes Morris's interest in the fourteenth century directly to Marx. She writes, "One thing reading Marx probably did for Morris was to turn his attention to the latter part of the Middle Ages, particularly the fourteenth century, which Marx saw as the most prosperous period that labor has ever known and the dividing point between feudalism and capitalism." Chandler, *A Dream of Order*, 220. For an excellent overview and analysis of the portrayal of medieval society in Marx and Engels's work, see Stephen H. Rigby, "Historical Materialism: Social Structure and Social Change in the Middle Ages," *The Journal of Medieval and Early Modern Studies* 34, no. 3 (Fall 2004): 473–522.

⁵⁹ William Morris, *News from Nowhere* (1890; repr., London: Penguin, 1998), 53.

him was that arising from the projection of an idealized nineteenth-century bourgeois childhood into an idealized Communist future.⁶⁰

In portraying a privileged life in which people do not revert to laziness, Morris plays upon child-like exuberance for experience and occupation as part of the motivation to perform labor. He equates the experience of work with the experience of "child's play," thus making work itself an enjoyable and enviable task. In attempting to establish a thorough equality in Nowhere, Morris has elevated all its citizens to the privileged position of childhood in which work is play and all people may do as they wish; fortunately, what people wish to do in Nowhere is also what is good for them and for society.⁶¹

Arguably, when read through a Marxist lens, the child-like quality of the people of Nowhere also relates to their cultural affinity for the Middle Ages. In his discussion of Greek art, Marx employs a metaphor of childhood and adulthood to explain why people enjoy the art produced in earlier societies:

But the difficulty lies not in understanding that Greek art and epic poetry are bound up with certain forms of social development. The difficulty is that they still give us aesthetic pleasure and are in certain respects regarded as a standard and an unattainable model.

An adult cannot become a child again, or he becomes childish. But does not the naiveté of the child give him pleasure, and must he not himself endeavor to reproduce the child's veracity on a higher level? Does not the specific character of every epoch come to life again in its natural veracity in the child's nature? Why should not the historical childhood of humanity, where it attained its most beautiful form, exert an eternal charm that will never return? There are unbred children and precocious children. Many of the ancient peoples belong to this category. The Greeks were normal children. The charm their art has for us does not conflict with the immature stage of society on which it originated. On the contrary, that charm is a consequence of this and is, rather, inseparably linked with the

⁶⁰ Michael Holzman, "The Pleasures of William Morris's Twenty-Second Century," *The Journal of Pre-Raphaelite Studies* 4, no. 1 (1983): 33.

⁶¹ The similarities between Morris's Nowhere and the society imagined in Thomas More's *Utopia* is no coincidence; Morris not only read More's text, but composed the foreword to the 1893 edition of *Utopia* produced by the Kelmscott Press. See Morris, foreword to *Utopia* (Kelmscott Press, 1893).

fact that the immature social conditions which gave rise, and which alone could give rise, to this art can never recur.⁶²

Marx associates earlier “forms of social development,” such as that of the ancient Greeks, with childhood, and current social forms with adulthood. While Marx sees the appeal of such “childish” art to adults as stemming from its association with a period of economic development that did not involve the exploitation of capitalism, Morris borrows from this metaphor while turning it on its head. For Morris the art of “childhood” – the artistic simplicity of the Middle Ages – does not invoke a comforting memory of the simpler economic form of feudalism, but instead serves as a means to maintain and enjoy the more advanced economic system of socialism. Morris has taken the “unattainable ideal” of medieval culture and transformed it into the means through which an entire society happily participates in a deceptively complex economic system. In *Nowhere* people want to work communally, because work is a game that perpetuates childhood through the recreated simplicity of an idealized medieval culture.

As critics such as Chester Scoville have noted, the prelapsarian quality of Tolkien’s Shire echoes the futurist utopia Morris creates in *News from Nowhere*.⁶³ Similar to Morris’s *Nowhere*, Tolkien’s Shire incorporates elements of medieval culture as the backdrop for an idyllic society whose residential hobbits operate largely in ignorance of the dangers that lurk outside its borders in Middle-earth at large. This privileged innocence suggests childhood as it does in *Nowhere*, and is only reinforced by Tolkien’s association of the short stature of hobbits with children, describing them as “a little people, smaller than Dwarves” (*The Lord of the Rings*, 1); at one point they are described to a character unfamiliar with hobbits as “small, only children to your eyes” (*The Lord of the Rings*, 424). The residents of the Shire also resemble those of *Nowhere* in their general exuberance and generosity. Tolkien describes them as “a merry folk” and “hospitable and delighted in parties, and in presents, which they gave away freely and eagerly accepted” (*The Lord of the Rings*, 2). Furthermore, as Brian Rosebury argues, hobbits in general reflect Tolkien’s propensity

⁶² Karl Marx, “Introduction” to *Economic Manuscripts 1857–8* (*Grundrisse*), in *Karl Marx, Frederick Engels: Collected Works*, vol. 28. (New York: International Publishers, 1975), 47–8.

⁶³ Chester Scoville, “Pastoralia and Perfectability in William Morris and J. R. R. Tolkien,” in *Tolkien’s Modern Middle Ages*, ed. Jane Chance and Alfred K. Siewers (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 93–103.

towards “an attitude to work which was close to John Ruskin’s, and not too remote from Marx’s. All the benign peoples in Tolkien have a distinctive kind of productive work.”⁶⁴ Tolkien writes, of the hobbits’ response to the cleanup needed after Saruman is ousted from the Shire, “Hobbits can work like bees when the mood and the need comes on them. Now there were thousands of willing hands of all ages, from the small but nimble ones of the hobbit lads and lasses to the well-worn and horny ones of the gaffers and gammers” (*The Lord of the Rings*, 999). Like the people of Nowhere, hobbits are happily and willingly productive, even if their society is structured more closely to Scott’s paternalistic ideal than Morris’s socialist utopia.⁶⁵

As indicated by Tolkien’s letters, Morris’s prose romances also influenced Tolkien.⁶⁶ In 1889 Morris published *The House of the Wolfings*, followed the next year by *The Roots of the Mountains*. Based loosely on early medieval Gothic tribes, both romances are often considered part historical novel, part fantasy novel (a genre that some critics credit Morris with inventing).⁶⁷ Morris followed these with a series of purely fantastic novels, including *The Wood Beyond the World* (1894), *The Well at the World’s End* (1896), and *The Water of the Wondrous Isles* (1897). In addition to providing Tolkien with models of fantasy writing that he admitted to imitating, these romances inspired many place and character names of Middle-earth (e.g., “Mirkwood” from *The House of the Wolfings* and “Gandolf” from *The Well at the World’s End*).

Although fantasy may seem out of place with Morris’s later socialist writing, critics have made links between Morris’s romances and his socialist politics.⁶⁸ Furthermore, the ability of fantasy texts to do critical work has been long acknowledged, especially in socialist aesthetics. In an 1888 letter to Margaret Harkness, Friedrich Engels, describing the ability

⁶⁴ Brian Rosebury, *Tolkien: A Cultural Phenomenon* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003), 161.

⁶⁵ Bilbo and Frodo, for instance, both inherit wealth that allows them to function as “gentlemen,” while Sam, clearly from a different economic background, works as Frodo’s gardener.

⁶⁶ See Letter 1 in Carpenter, *The Letters of J. R. R. Tolkien*, 7.

⁶⁷ Scoville, “Pastoralia and Perfectability,” 93.

⁶⁸ Anna Vaninskaya, *William Morris and the Idea of Community: Romance, History and Propaganda, 1880–1914* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2010). Notably, even Morris’s translations have been linked to his socialism; see Michael R. Kightley, “Socialism and Translation: The Folks of William Morris’s *Beowulf*,” *Studies in Medievalism* XXIII (2014): 167–88.

of fantastic works by Honoré de Balzac to expose “real” conditions (for Engels this would have meant the conditions of production) of the world in which he wrote, notes:

Realism, to my mind, implies, besides truth of detail, the truthful reproduction of typical characters under typical circumstances The realism I allude to may crop out even in spite of the author’s opinions. Let me refer to an example. Balzac, whom I consider a far greater master of realism than all the Zolas passés, présents et à venir.⁶⁹

Engels’s sentiments are later crystallized in the work of George Lukacs, who sees the goal of a true Marxist aesthetic as to reveal the essential “dynamic” or productive forces at work, even if that means employing the techniques of fantasy.⁷⁰ The broader applicability of fantasy as critique has, as noted above, been ably stated by Tom Shippey, who reads Tolkien and his contemporary fantasists (including George Orwell, William Golding, Kurt Vonnegut, T. H. White, C. S. Lewis, and Ursula Le Guin) as writing in their fantasy about some of the most pressing issues of the twentieth century.⁷¹ Tolkien, as we will see below, stands out among his fellow fantasists both for the unique methods by which he incorporated medievalism into his fantasy, and for the influence he had on later fantasy writers.

Medievalist to Middle-Earth

Although Tolkien’s “creative” works – *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* especially – have most obviously shaped the course of medievalism from the mid-twentieth century on, as Jane Chance has succinctly surmised, Tolkien’s creative writing is in truth inseparable from his “academic” writing. She states, “Tolkien did not compartmentalize the writing of his scholarly or philological essays and notes and the writing of his fiction (that is, his professional contribution to medieval studies from his personal and private creating, or vice versa).”⁷² This becomes apparent when reading some of the common themes that are prevalent

⁶⁹ Friedrich Engels, “Letter to Margaret Harkness,” April 1888, repr. in *On Literature and Art* (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1976), 90–1.

⁷⁰ Georg Lukacs, “Marx and Engels on Aesthetics,” in *Writer & Critic and Other Essays*, ed. and trans. Arthur Kahn (New York: Grosset & Dunlap, 1971), 61–88; see esp. 78–80.

⁷¹ Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*, xvii.

⁷² Jane Chance, *Tolkien’s Art*, vii–viii.

in his professional and fictional work: the portrayal of dragons, the importance of language, and the role of culture in both constructing and reconstructing distinctly “medieval” worlds.

In examining the ways in which Tolkien’s professional and creative writing intersect, it is perhaps best to start with a dragon: the impetus for Tolkien’s first known written endeavor. As noted above, Tolkien originally encountered dragons through an adaptation of Morris’s translation of the *Völsunga Saga*; he later, of course, read the text in its original Old Norse.⁷³ In his famous lecture “On Fairy-Stories,” originally delivered at St. Andrews in 1939 and later revised for print, Tolkien writes of his impression of Fafnir, the “prince of all dragons”:

But the land of Merlin and Arthur was better than these, and best of all the nameless North of Sigurd of the Völsungs, and the prince of all dragons. Such lands were pre-eminently desirable. I never imagined that the dragon was of the same order as the horse. And that was not solely because I saw horses daily, but never even the footprint of a worm. The dragon had the trade-mark *Of Faërie* written plainly on him. In whatever world he had his being it was an Otherworld. Fantasy, the making or glimpsing of Other-worlds, was the heart of the desire of Faërie. I desired dragons with a profound desire.⁷⁴

Tolkien’s affinity for dragons manifests elsewhere in his professional writing, but it is most evident in “*Beowulf*: The Monsters and the Critics.” Although Tolkien discusses Grendel,⁷⁵ his analysis of the dragon in *Beowulf* proves far more extensive as he lauds the poem’s characterization of the creature.

Although dragons have a long literary and mythological history in the Middle Ages,⁷⁶ as Tolkien observes, the poem *Beowulf* itself provides a

⁷³ Tolkien was later critical of some of Morris’s translation work, especially as regards his 1895 translation of *Beowulf*. See J. R. R. Tolkien, “On Translating *Beowulf*,” in *The Monsters and the Critics and Other Essays*, ed. Christopher Tolkien (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1983), 56.

⁷⁴ Tolkien, “On Fairy-Stories,” 135.

⁷⁵ Tolkien pointedly omits an analysis of Grendel’s mother. See Jane Chance, “The Structural Unity of *Beowulf*: The Problem of Grendel’s Mother,” *Texas Studies in Literature and Language* 22, no. 3 (1980): 287–303.

⁷⁶ As Gwyyn Jones has noted, “That a man fights a dragon is a commonplace of story, and appears in medieval literature as myth, folktale, heroic legend, saint’s life, onomastic anecdote, romance, and quasi-history. So many heroes over so many centuries killed so many dragons, from Frotho and Fridlevus to Ragnar Hairybreeks, and from Sigurd to St George, that the

legendary history for dragons and a heroic exemplum of slaying them. After the Geat hero Beowulf defeats the monster Grendel at the Danish court of Heorot, a scop tells the story of Sigemund at the celebratory feast.⁷⁷ Sigemund's story foreshadows much of what Beowulf will do later in the poem, as he kills a dragon, recovers a treasure, and eventually dies fighting against impossible odds. Of this sub-narrative within the poem, Tolkien writes:

Although there is plainly considerable difference between the later Norse and the ancient English form of the story alluded to in *Beowulf*, already there it had these two primary features: the dragon, and the slaying of him as the chief deed of the greatest of heroes – *he wæs wreccena wide mærost*. A dragon is no idle fancy.⁷⁸

Tolkien goes on to argue that the Sigemund legend elevates the status of the dragon that Beowulf later slays, establishing it as an enemy of hero lore and not simply another “monster” that Beowulf must eradicate. Furthermore, as the stuff of heroic legend within the poem, the dragon serves as a suitable end to Beowulf, who dies from wounds incurred while killing it. In regards to Beowulf's death, Tolkien states, “For the universal significance which is given to the fortunes of its hero it is an enhancement and not a detracting, in fact it is necessary, that his final foe should be not some Swedish prince, or treacherous friend, but a dragon.”⁷⁹ The legendary status of the dragon, then, justifies Beowulf's actions, furthers his reputation, and allows him to preserve his reputation even in death.

Notably, Tolkien reads the dragon's legendary status within the poem as one of the linguistic and cultural details that the poem uses to emulate an era that was, at the time of the poem's composition, already part of the distant past. Tolkien, writing of the *Beowulf* poet, states:

He cast his time into the long-ago, because already the long-ago had a special poetic attraction. He knew much about the old days, and though his knowledge – of such things as sea-burial and the funeral pyre, for instance – was rich and poetical rather than accurate with the accuracy

presence of one, or even two, dragons in a poem inclined to monsters is no surprise.” See Jones, *Kings, Beasts, and Heroes* (London and New York: Oxford University Press, 1972), 15–16.

⁷⁷ “Scop” is an Old English word for a poet who would compose, learn, and perform material from memory.

⁷⁸ Tolkien, “*Beowulf*: The Monsters and the Critics,” 16.

⁷⁹ *Ibid.*, 31.



of modern archaeology (such as that is), one thing he knew clearly: those days were heathen – heathen, noble, and hopeless.⁸⁰

As part of his argument that *Beowulf* should be read “as a poem” and not as a mere historic artifact, Tolkien attributes what he sees as the conscious construction of the poem’s setting in the past as the result of the skill and intention of the poet. He argues, “The illusion of historical truth and perspective, that has made *Beowulf* seem such an attractive quarry, is largely a product of art.”⁸¹ In *Beowulf*, then, we have a medieval poem that recreates an even earlier era of the Middle Ages: a distinction that is missed if the poem is read merely as “history,” “mythology,” “folklore,” or even “archeology.”

Tolkien’s commendation of the anonymous *Beowulf* poet for so skillfully practicing his “art,” especially in the representation of the dragon, extends to a suggestion that the combination of subject matter and artistic execution has proven inspirational for modern poets:⁸² “More than one poem in recent years (since *Beowulf* escaped somewhat from the dominion of the students of origins to the students of poetry) has been inspired by the dragon of *Beowulf*, but none that I know of by Ingeld son of Froda.”⁸³ Tolkien may well have been speaking about himself; as Tom Shippey has argued, both Tolkien’s 1923 poem “Iumonna Gold Galdre Bewunden”⁸⁴ and his characterization of Smaug in *The Hobbit* are indebted to the *Beowulf* dragon.⁸⁵ Tolkien’s borrowing of events from *Beowulf* is clear: Bilbo awakens Smaug by stealing a cup from his hoard of gold, as does a thief in *Beowulf*. I would argue, however, that Tolkien’s debt to *Beowulf* goes further: in Smaug, Tolkien creates a dragon who is part of a larger dragon-lore of Middle-earth as indicated by cues within *The Hobbit* and the dragons included in *The Silmarillion*; the similarity to the *Beowulf* dragon’s foreshadowing by Fafnir is obvious. Indeed, the casting of the events of *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* in a setting

⁸⁰ Ibid., 22.

⁸¹ Ibid., 7.

⁸² Through his use of masculine pronouns when describing the *Beowulf* poet, Tolkien implies his assumption that the poet was a man.

⁸³ Tolkien, “*Beowulf*: The Monsters and the Critics,” 16.

⁸⁴ Shippey translates the title as “the gold of ancient men, wound round with magic.” *The Road to Middle-Earth*, 87.

⁸⁵ Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*, 86–7. For additional studies on the role of medieval literature in Tolkien’s fiction, see Chance, *Tolkien’s Art*; the remainder of Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*; and Jane Chance, ed. and intro., *Tolkien the Medievalist* (New York and London: Routledge, 2003).

that is inspired by the Middle Ages and complete with its own historical, legendary, and mythological past is both an example of Tolkien's own art and a nod to the art of the *Beowulf* poet.

This immersive quality of Middle-earth serves an example of what Tolkien calls a "Secondary World" in his famous lecture and essay "On Fairy-Stories." Tolkien writes of the term, which is widely used in studies of both medievalism and fantasy:

What really happens is that the story-maker proves a successful "sub-creator." He makes a Secondary World which your mind can enter. Inside it, what he relates is "true": it accords with the laws of that world. You therefore believe it, while you are, as it were, inside. The moment disbelief arises, the spell is broken; the magic, or rather art, has failed. You are then out in the Primary World again.⁸⁶

In Middle-earth, then, Tolkien creates a Secondary World according to the premises he lays out in his scholarly work.

Notably, Tolkien imagines Middle-earth as located thousands of years ago in the space that now constitutes England. Humphrey Carpenter, Tolkien's biographer, famously ascribes part of Tolkien's motivation for writing about Middle-earth to "a desire to create a mythology for England," as to Tolkien's eyes England lacked the mythological riches of Old Norse, Greek, or even Finnish tradition.⁸⁷ As a result, Middle-earth is constructed through the tropes of a medievalist: Tolkien casts himself as a translator/scholar who has found the texts that constitute both *The Hobbit* (renamed *There and Back Again*, and written by Bilbo) and *The Lord of the Rings* (written by Frodo and Sam). Both texts were purportedly found in the fictional Red Book of Westmarch (*The Lord of the Rings*, 1), a manuscript for which Tolkien provides its own history (*The Lord of the Rings*, 13–15).

The language of this found manuscript is named "Westron" or "the Common Speech," which Tolkien's narrator claims to translate into modern English (*The Lord of the Rings*, 1101); he furthermore provides detailed notes on the translation and how he chose to represent the other languages of Middle-earth (*The Lord of the Rings*, 1107–12). Many other languages of Middle-earth are therefore represented by "Primary World" languages and their relationship to modern English. The language of the Rohirrim, for instance, is largely Anglo-Saxon, and is meant to represent

⁸⁶ J. R. R. Tolkien, "On Fairy-Stories," 132.

⁸⁷ Carpenter, *J. R. R. Tolkien: A Biography*, 97.

a more archaic version of Westron; the elder language of Dale, which lies to the north, is largely represented by Old Norse.

In addition to the incorporation of known languages into Middle-earth, Tolkien also used his knowledge as a philologist to create languages that were modeled after the medieval languages he studied.⁸⁸ The most fully formed (and generally well-known) are the elven languages Quenya and Sindarin. Quenya, also called “High-elven” at the time in which most of the action of *The Lord of the Rings* takes place, functions as a formal, older language (a sort of “elven Latin”). It has its roots in Finnish, the language of the *Kalevala*: the national poem of Finland that is often cited as an influence on Tolkien’s Middle-earth.⁸⁹ Sindarin, which is also known as “Grey-elven” and is the primary spoken language of the elves in *The Lord of the Rings*, was based heavily on both Welsh and Latin.⁹⁰ Notably, Tolkien developed both languages to the extent that he gave each its own history in relation to the events of the earlier ages of Middle-earth depicted in *The Silmarillion*, including etymologies and sound shifts.

Tolkien’s use and creation of language have played a key role in casting Middle-earth as a fully realized Secondary World; for Tolkien, however, the invention of languages was the impetus for creating Middle-earth in the first place. In replying to an interviewer’s attempt to split his philological and fictional work Tolkien writes:

The authorities of the university might well consider it an aberration of an elderly professor of philology to write and publish fairy stories and romances, and call it a “hobby,” pardonable because it has been (surprising to me as anyone) successful. But it is not a “hobby,” in the sense of something quite different from one’s work, taken up as a relief-outlet. The invention of languages is the foundation. The “stories” were made rather to provide a world for the languages than the reverse. To me a name comes first and the story follows.⁹¹

⁸⁸ See Jeffrey, “Tolkien as Philologist,” 64. Depending on how one defines “language,” Tolkien arguably created at least ten languages for Middle-earth.

⁸⁹ Richard C. West, “Setting the Rocket Off in Story: The *Kalevala* as the Germ of Tolkien’s *Legendarium*,” in *Tolkien and the Invention of Myth*, ed. Jane Chance (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 2004), 285–94 (see esp. 286–7).

⁹⁰ Deidre Dawson, “English, Welsh, and Elvish: Language, Loss, and Cultural Recovery in J. R. R. Tolkien’s *The Lord of the Rings*,” in *Tolkien’s Modern Middle Ages*, ed. Jane Chance and Alfred K. Siewers (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 105–20.

⁹¹ Letter 165 in Carpenter, *The Letters of J. R. R. Tolkien*, 219.

Indeed, Tolkien is known to have been working on languages as early as World War I, even before he began developing the mythology that would later be published in *The Silmarillion*.⁹² Even the origins of *The Hobbit* and its follow-up, *The Lord of the Rings*, lie in an act of naming. As Tolkien recounts in a footnote to the above letter: "I once scribbled 'hobbit' on a blank page of some boring school exam paper in the early 1930's. It was some time before I discovered what it referred to!"⁹³ Even hobbits had a name before Tolkien had imagined any other of their characteristics or the narratives in which they would play a tremendous part.

Although Tolkien freely admitted to the role that real and invented languages played in the shaping of Middle-earth, he was resistant to attributions of other aspects of his fictional work to specific sources.⁹⁴ As a particularly pertinent example, Tolkien directly disavows any connection between the fictional Rohirrim and historic Anglo-Saxons outside of the obvious and acknowledged linguistic one whereby the Anglo-Saxon language was selected to represent Rohirric as a more archaic form of Westron. In Appendix F to *The Lord of the Rings* he writes:

This linguistic procedure does not imply that the Rohirrim closely resembled the ancient English otherwise, in culture or art, in weapons or modes of warfare, except in a general way due to their circumstances: a simpler and more primitive people living in contact with a higher and more venerable culture, and occupying lands that had once been part of its domain.

(*The Lord of the Rings*, 1110)

In spite of such protestations, many of the customs and actions of the Rohirrim, including the drinking hall of Medusheld at Edoras (*The Lord of the Rings*, 495–6), Eowyn's offering of the guest cup (*The Lord of the Rings*, 511), and the general characterization of battle and death, are

⁹² John Garth, *Tolkien and the Great War: The Threshold of Middle-earth* (New York: Houghton Mifflin, 2003), 60–3. Garth's study, which is part biography and part literary analysis, provides an excellent overview of how the Great War was influential on both the languages and mythology of Middle-earth.

⁹³ Carpenter also recounts this story, yet credits the event with producing not just the word "hobbit" but the complete initial sentence of what would be *The Hobbit*: "In a hole in the ground there lived a hobbit." See *J. R. R. Tolkien: A Biography*, 175.

⁹⁴ Jason Fisher, "Tolkien and Source Criticism: Remarking and Remaking," in *Tolkien and the Study of His Sources*, ed. Jason Fisher (Jefferson, NC: McFarland, 2011), 29–44.

clearly similar to those attributed to the Anglo-Saxons. In his argument that the Rohirrim are very much indebted to the Anglo-Saxons, Thomas Honegger cites authorities no less than Tom Shippey and Christopher Tolkien, concluding that “Both agree that the Rohirrim are basically Anglo-Saxons – though with some differences.”⁹⁵ One such difference: the Rohirrim’s skill with horses, for which Honegger suggests inspiration in the Goths.⁹⁶

In spite of Tolkien’s assertions to the contrary, such cultural references to medieval sources abound in Middle-earth. The kingdom of Gondor, for instance, which is represented at the time of *The Lord of the Rings* as having fallen into decay following an earlier period of expansion and prosperity, has been read as invoking the Byzantine empire.⁹⁷ The feudal allegiance that many of the smaller realms of Middle-earth owe to Gondor (e.g., Rohan and Dol Amroth) again mimics social structures of medieval Europe. Even the courtly culture of Galadriel’s dwelling at Lothlórien has antecedents in the culture of the high Middle Ages: the arrangement and décor of the halls and pavilions, the announcement and treatment of guests, and Galadriel’s practice of surrounding herself with ladies as attendants with whom she weaves (*The Lord of the Rings*, 345–61).

Therefore, while Tolkien may cite language alone as his impetus for writing *The Lord of the Rings*, he also relied on his extensive knowledge of medieval history, literature, and culture to create the history, language, and mythology of Middle-earth. Tolkien created in *The Lord of the Rings* a book that consistently tops various “best books” lists;⁹⁸ he furthermore founded the popular fantasy genre that arose in the late twentieth century.⁹⁹ In an attempt to capitalize on the popularity of Middle-earth, of the fantastic world constructed through *The Lord of the Rings*, *The*

⁹⁵ Thomas Honegger, “The Rohirrim: ‘Anglo-Saxons on Horseback’? An Inquiry into Tolkien’s Use of Sources,” in *Tolkien and the Study of His Sources*, ed. Jason Fisher (Jefferson, NC: MacFarland, 2011), 121.

⁹⁶ *Ibid.*, 123.

⁹⁷ Miryam Librán-Moreno, “Byzantium, New Rome! Goths, Langobards, and Byzantium in *The Lord of the Rings*,” in *Tolkien and the Study of His Sources*, ed. Jason Fisher (Jefferson, NC: MacFarland, 2011), 84–115.

⁹⁸ For a sampling and analysis of such lists see Tom Shippey, *J. R. R. Tolkien: Author of the Century* (Boston and New York: Houghton Mifflin, 2000), xx–xxiv.

⁹⁹ David G. Hartwell “The Making of the Fantasy Genre,” in *The Secret History of Fantasy*, ed. Peter S. Beagle (San Francisco: Tachyon, 2010), 367–79.

Hobbit, and *The Silmarillion*, publishers looked to satiate readers' hunger for "not more *fantasy* but more *Tolkien*."¹⁰⁰ Notably, they specifically sought out texts that imitated Tolkien's emphasis on medievalism in their own world-building, resulting in the production of a flood of what can be termed medievalist fantasy that continues well into the twenty-first century with such neomedieval texts as Robert B. Jordan's *Wheel of Time* books and George R. R. Martin's *A Song of Ice and Fire* series.¹⁰¹

While direct adaptations of Tolkien's texts into films, video games, and even action figures would provide meat enough for their own study, the larger medievalist fantasy genre that he helped invent has also resulted in the film and television production of other medievalist fantasy writing, such as the popular *Game of Thrones* adaptation of Martin's books, as well as texts that are created primarily as film or other digital media. As Tom Shippey notes, "Tolkien furthermore provided much of the inspiration, the personnel and the material, for early fantasy games and for role-playing games of the 'Dungeons and Dragons' type Spin-offs from these into computer games are still developing and multiplying."¹⁰² In short, a large number of the texts that shape the way the world sees the Middle Ages are a direct result of Tolkien's Middle-earth, which began with such a modest sentence: "In a hole in the ground there lived a hobbit."¹⁰³

Middle-Earth: Tolkien and the Critics

In his analysis of political critique in the fantasy writings of Tolkien and his fellow Inkling C. S. Lewis, Lee Rossi writes:

¹⁰⁰ Ibid., 375.

¹⁰¹ I follow the practice of such scholars as Helen Young and Shiloh Carroll in using the term "medievalist fantasy" to refer to fantasy fiction that relies on medieval tropes. Young uses the term in much of her public and academic writing; see especially Young, *Race and Popular Fantasy Literature: Habits of Whiteness* (New York and London: Routledge, 2016), 81–3. Carroll uses "medievalist fantasy" (and, when appropriate, "neomedieval fantasy") throughout *Medievalism in A Song of Ice and Fire and Game of Thrones* (Cambridge: D. S. Brewer, 2018); see especially Carroll's introduction on "Martin and Medievalist Fantasy." I analyze these concepts further in Chapters 4 and 5.

¹⁰² Shippey, *J. R. R. Tolkien: Author of the Century*, xxv.

¹⁰³ J. R. R. Tolkien, *The Hobbit, or There and Back Again* (1937; repr., New York: Houghton Mifflin, 1997).

Tolkien and Lewis are two of the more recent heirs of a long tradition of culturally reactionary fantasists that goes back to at least Scott and includes such figures as George MacDonald, John Ruskin, William Morris, Lord Dunsany, and E. R. Eddison. Taken together, these authors constitute a cultural rearguard of the Middle Ages.¹⁰⁴

Fantasy in general and medievalist fantasy in particular thus have a storied history throughout the nineteenth century as critical tools. Tolkien and his nineteenth-century medieval fantasist forebears, then, exemplify the various ways in which representations of the “medieval” could reflect, represent, translate, critique, and idealize not only the Middle Ages, but also contemporary society.

Although Tolkien himself disavowed any connection between his creative work and the events of the twentieth century,¹⁰⁵ his incorporation of these themes (consciously or otherwise) into his fictional rather than professionally critical work meant that his ideas reached a readership much wider than the formal field of medieval studies. As Tom Shippey observes:

On some subjects Tolkien simply knew more, and had thought more deeply, than anyone else in the world. Some have felt (and said) that he should have written his results up in academic treatises instead of fantasy fiction. He might then have been taken more seriously by a limited academic audience. On the other hand, all through his lifetime that academic audience was shrinking, and has now all but vanished.¹⁰⁶

Regardless of Tolkien's intentions, and in spite of what may have seemed an appropriate critical venue during the time in which it was created, Tolkien's “mythology for England” is nevertheless read as using medievalism to critique the conditions of the twentieth century, as critic after critic has read Middle-earth as a site of commentary on everything from industrialization to ecological irresponsibility to modern warfare.

Tolkien's hobbits, his original creation, are in particular read as both a critique against industrialization and a product of Tolkien's nostalgia for the rural England of his childhood. As Tom Shippey notes, the hobbits and their comfortable home in the Shire are themselves somewhat out of place in the otherwise medievaesque realm of Middle-earth. He writes,

¹⁰⁴ Lee D. Rossi, *The Politics of Fantasy: C. S. Lewis and J. R. R. Tolkien* (Ann Arbor, MI: UMI Research Press, 1984), 2.

¹⁰⁵ *Ibid.*, 89.

¹⁰⁶ Shippey, *J. R. R. Tolkien: Author of the Century*, ix.

"I consider in particular the literary function of hobbits, and of Bilbo Baggins, their representative. I argue that they are above all anachronism, creatures of the early modern world of Tolkien's youth drawn, like Bilbo, into the far more archaic and heroic world of dwarves and dragons, wargs and were-bears."¹⁰⁷ Although largely absent from the earlier mythology of *The Silmarillion*, hobbits serve as the narrative entry and exit points to both *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*. The reader thus starts with Bilbo in *The Hobbit*, and with Frodo, Sam, Merry, and Pippin in *The Lord of the Rings*, in the nostalgic, pre-industrial, yet somewhat familiar Shire, a place that espouses a love for "peace and quiet and good tilled earth," and a complementary distrust of "machines more complicated than a forge-bellows, a water-mill, or a hand-loom" (*The Lord of the Rings*, 1). It is a space where tea, pipe-weed, and the neighborhood pub mimic the familiar comforts of a typical English village, yet where the factories, colonial practices, and technological advances responsible for bringing such comforts to England are noticeably absent.

As the hobbits venture out from the Shire, Tolkien brings with them a viewpoint that, like many of Tolkien's readers, finds the medievalist fantasy elements of Middle-earth partly alien and yet also partly familiar: for the hobbits, this familiarity comes through the myth-lore prevalent in the Shire, while for the readers it comes through the aspects of adapted medievalism and medieval material proper that Tolkien incorporates into his own legendarium.¹⁰⁸ As the hobbits negotiate these elements, the Shire remains an idealized and safe place to which they long to return throughout their adventures; however, in "The Scouring of the Shire," the penultimate chapter of *The Lord of the Rings*, their return is marred by the industrializing infestation of the wizard Saruman and his cronies.

Having earlier converted the fortress of Isengard into a production zone for both his army of Uruk-hai (orc-goblin hybrids who are bred in the ground) and the weapons that they wield, Saruman had already been associated with machinery, industrialism, and technology.¹⁰⁹ After

¹⁰⁷ Ibid., xxvii. In Tolkien "wargs" are large wolf-like creatures.

¹⁰⁸ In addition to the dragons, languages, and cultural representations that are discussed above, Tolkien's Middle-earth incorporates elves (present in Morris), dwarves (Old Norse myth), powerful wizards (Arthurian legend, the Finnish *Kalevala*, and Morris again), and grand fortresses (evident throughout the landscape of a post-Romanized and post-Norman-invasion Britain).

¹⁰⁹ As Tom Shippey has pointed out, Saruman's very name may be derived from a Mercian word for "device, design, contrivance, art." See Shippey, *The Road to Middle-Earth*, 170. Saruman's earlier workings at Isengard can be

his defeat by the hobbits' allies at Helmsdeep, Saruman fled north, where he was able to seize control of an unsuspecting Shire and implement a regime by which the hobbits of the Shire are forced to labor for Saruman's gain in a noticeably changed landscape. When Frodo and Sam return to the Shire, they note:

Many of the houses that they had known were missing. Some seemed to have been burned down. The pleasant row of old hobbit-holes in the bank on the north side of the Pool were deserted, and their little gardens that used to run down bright to the water's edge were rank with weeds. Worse, there was a whole line of ugly new houses all along Pool Side, where the Hobbiton Road ran close to the bank. An avenue of trees had stood there. They were all gone. And looking with dismay up the road towards Bag End they saw a tall chimney of brick in the distance. It was pouring out black smoke into the evening air.

(*The Lord of the Rings*, 981)

Having experienced sieges, battle, and other horrendous events outside the Shire, Frodo, Sam, Merry, and Pippin organize the other hobbits and drive out Saruman and his accomplices (the "Scouring" of the chapter title), thus starting the Shire on a restorative path to its prior idyllic state.

The characterization of Saruman, both at Isengard and during his tenure of the Shire, makes a clear statement against industrialization, exploitation of labor, and greed. The pre-Saruman (and post-Scouring) Shire, in contrast, exemplifies a seemingly perfect balance of craft (in the artisanal sense that produces good ale and pipe-weed), a desire for order, and an implicit assertion that most people, if left to their own devices, will be able and willing to labor enough to provide for themselves. The ease with which the Shire is overrun by Saruman, however, suggests that its very existence is one of privileged innocence that is not sustainable without external intervention. That Frodo and company, having learned the workings of the "far more archaic and heroic world" outside the Shire so easily dispatch Saruman upon their return suggests that the survival

summed up as follows: "The plain, too, was bored and delved. Shafts were driven deep into the ground; their upper ends were covered by low mounds and domes of stone, so that in the moonlight the Ring of Isengard looked like a graveyard of unquiet dead. For the ground trembled. The shafts ran down by many slopes and spiral stairs to caverns far under; there Saruman had treasuries, store-houses, armouries, smithies, and great furnaces. Iron wheels revolved there endlessly, and hammers thudded" (*The Lord of the Rings*, 541).

of an idyllic place like the Shire is dependent upon the values of a more mediaevalesque landscape.

As Alfred K. Siewers notes, Tolkien's negative portrayal of industrialization is often also read as a "green" or ecologically minded critique of the twentieth century. Such readings of Tolkien have been more prevalent in recent years, partly due to the increasing interest in green studies and eco-critical theoretical approaches, and partly due to the visual representations of Saruman's destruction of nature in Peter Jackson's film adaptations of *The Lord of the Rings*.¹¹⁰ Siewers writes, "Green/antimodernist popular readings of Tolkien ... are stronger than ever in the wake of recent film portrayals of Saruman's Isengard as a forest-consuming industrial hellhole engaged in genetic engineering."¹¹¹ Although the films may visually highlight Saruman's handiwork, Tolkien's writing makes it very clear that felling the trees of Fangorn Forest is part of Saruman's project. The reader learns of Saruman's activity through words of the ent Treebeard:¹¹² "Down on the border they are felling trees – good trees. Some of the trees they just cut down and leave to rot – orc-mischief that; but most are hewn up and carried off to feed the fires of Orthanc. There is always a smoke rising from Isengard these days" (*The Lord of the Rings*, 462). That control of Isengard is wrested from Saruman by Treebeard and his fellow ents as a response to Saruman's felling of the forests initially appears to be a clear eco-statement that forwards tree protection; because of their hybridity, the tree-like yet anthropomorphic ents have also been read as a personification of nature taking revenge on Isengard.¹¹³

As Verilyn Flieger points out, however, the felling of trees is also performed by hobbits in the Old Forest without any kind of negative consequences, suggesting that any "green" messages in Tolkien's fiction

¹¹⁰ Jackson's films include *The Fellowship of the Ring* (2001), *The Two Towers* (2002), and *The Return of the King* (2003). He has followed these with a three-part adaptation of *The Hobbit*.

¹¹¹ Alfred K. Siewers, "Tolkien's Cosmic-Christian Ecology: The Medieval Underpinnings," in *Tolkien's Modern Middle Ages*, ed. Jane Chance and Alfred K. Siewers (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 141.

¹¹² In Middle-earth an ent is a tree-herd, or shepherd of the trees, who can walk, talk, and go to war. Ents appear to be Tolkien's invention.

¹¹³ Siewers argues that Tolkien drew this personified view of nature from early Celtic mythology and presents it as a critique of a modern propensity to view nature as a mere object. See Siewers, "Tolkien's Cosmic-Christian Ecology," 139–41.

come across as somewhat mixed.¹¹⁴ Tolkien's judgment on both technology and ecology should never be read in an oversimplified, cut-and-dried manner; just as he allows for instances where trees may be felled for good reason, he makes clear distinctions between the "skill" of the elves and dwarves or the "craft" of hobbits, and the mindless technological developments associated with Saruman and Sauron. Indeed, while Saruman's activities at both Isengard and the Shire are widely read as reflecting the ecological consequences of industrialization, as Matthew Dickerson and Jonathan Evans observe, it is Mordor, Sauron's base of operations and the location where the One Ring was created, that is the ultimate casualty of ecological abuse.¹¹⁵ As Dickerson and Evans argue, the ash-ridden slopes and barren plains of Mordor prove most ecologically troublesome because of the long duration of the land's misuse; whereas Isengard and the Shire are recovered and healed within the timeframe of *The Lord of the Rings*, they argue that "In Mordor, the only hope for restoration of life would be something on the order of a cataclysmic flood."¹¹⁶

Green readings of Tolkien often coincide with readings of *The Lord of the Rings* as a critique of war. In addition to Tolkien's careful descriptions of the short-term ecological aftermath of various battles (burial mounds, burning bodies, slaughtered horses), the "Dead Marshes" point to the long-term effects of war on nature. Frodo and Sam, led by Gollum, traverse the Dead Marshes on their way to the Black Gate of Mordor and initially note the barren state of the landscape, which is devoid of birds and benevolent plant life (*The Lord of the Rings*, 612). As night descends on them Frodo and Sam are both struck by eerie lights in the marsh, "some like dimly shining smoke, some like misty flames flickering slowly above unseen candles" (*The Lord of the Rings*, 613). Frodo then sees the faces of the dead illuminated in the water: "They lie in all the pools, pale faces, deep deep under the dark water. I saw them: grim faces and evil, and noble faces and sad. Many faces proud and fair, and weeds in their

¹¹⁴ Verilyn Flieger, "Taking the Part of Trees: Eco-conflict in Middle-Earth," in *Green Suns and Faërie: Essays on J. R. R. Tolkien* (Kent, OH: Kent State University Press, 2012), 262–74. For an excellent and more general ecological reading of forests in (neo)medievalist texts, see Valerie B. Johnson, "Ecomedievalism: Applying Ecotheory to Medievalism and Neomedievalism," *Studies in Medievalism* XXIV (2015): 31–8.

¹¹⁵ Matthew Dickerson and Jonathan Evans, *Ents, Elves, and Eriador: The Environmental Vision of J. R. R. Tolkien* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 2006), 185–92.

¹¹⁶ *Ibid.*, 186–7.

silver hair. But all foul, all rotting, all dead. A fell light is in them" (*The Lord of the Rings*, 612). As Gollum explains, the Dead Marshes are the result of a largely forgotten battle between Sauron and an alliance of elves and men that ended the Second Age of Middle-earth. This battle, which occurred over 3,000 years before the main events of *The Lord of the Rings*, sets into motion the events by which the One Ring is lost and eventually recovered by Bilbo in *The Hobbit* and then passed on to Frodo in *The Lord of the Rings*.

While the Dead Marshes clearly mark the scarring of the landscape of Middle-earth by war, as Rebekah Long has argued, they also serve as an enduring war memorial. The representation of the casualties of battle as pale, ghostly faces in the pools, rather than through more heroic modes, is particularly significant in this regard: Long characterizes the marshes as "a textual actualization of the process of memory, in which the dead refuse to be resolved into statuelike icons, idealized narratives of victory or defeat traced across their frozen surfaces."¹¹⁷ In his account of Tolkien's experiences as an officer in the Great War, John Garth recounts how Tolkien himself, although reluctant to link the events of Middle-earth with those of his own life, admitted that the Dead Marshes echo scenes he witnessed in the Battle of the Somme.¹¹⁸

Although critics have debated whether *The Lord of the Rings* glorifies war or, on the contrary, argues for pacifism,¹¹⁹ the most convincing interpretations of Tolkien's representation of war in Middle-earth are those that do not reduce it to one extreme or the other. Janet Brennan Croft's reading of Tolkien as espousing "just war doctrine," for instance, argues that while Tolkien did not glorify war, he believed it was one's duty to fight when circumstances required it.¹²⁰ Clearly, however, Tolkien forwards a heavy critique of modern warfare, which he characterized

¹¹⁷ Rebekah Long, "Fantastic Medievalism and the Great War in J. R. R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings*," in *Tolkien's Modern Middle Ages*, ed. Jane Chance and Alfred K. Siewers (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 128.

¹¹⁸ John Garth, *Tolkien and the Great War*, 310–11.

¹¹⁹ For an excellent summary of both positions, see Janet Brennan Croft, *War and the Works of J. R. R. Tolkien* (Westport, CT: Praeger, 2004), esp. 6–8. Croft further analyzes Frodo's refusal to physically fight during the scouring of the Shire as both an act of pacifism and a potential manifestation of shellshock or PTSD (133–8).

¹²⁰ *Ibid.*, 138–47.

in his correspondence as “the War of the Machines.”¹²¹ As Croft notes, Tolkien’s dislike of airplanes in particular “may have been a symbol of all that was worst about modern warfare: the ability to kill from a distance without even seeing the face of your enemy, the lack of discrimination between combatant and noncombatant, and above all a thing being done simply because it could be done – not because it should be done.”¹²² This attitude toward war is aptly demonstrated in the battles of *The Lord of the Rings*, where Saruman and Sauron’s armies raid villages, kill innocent people, and attack the structures of Helmsdeep and Minas Tirith (which shield the non-military citizenry of Rohan and Gondor, respectively) with advanced siege weapons, gunpowder, and the aid of flying beasts commanded by Sauron’s servants, the Nazgûl. The elves, men, and dwarves of Middle-earth, in contrast, adhere to methods of warfare more closely linked to a heroic version of the Middle Ages: swords, bows, and axes wielded with skill by trained warriors.

Although much of Tolkien’s medievalism can be read as critique, the texts referenced above have also been read as naturalizing nineteenth- and early twentieth-century assumptions about gender, class, and race that would now be considered obsolete. As Candice Frederick and Sam McBride have argued, there is a dearth of women in Tolkien’s major works, and those who are present are often either characterized as passive or punished should they exhibit any agency.¹²³ They cite Éowyn, shield-maiden of Rohan in *The Lord of the Rings*, as a particularly apt example. Éowyn must disguise herself as a man so that she can participate in the battles that will shape the future of Rohan and Middle-earth. Although Tolkien characterizes her as a successful warrior – indeed, she slays the Witch-King, the head of Sauron’s Nazgûl – afterwards, after recovering from her injuries from the battle, she suddenly renounces her former life and pursuits to marry the Steward of Gondor, stating “I will be a shield-maiden no longer, nor vie with the great Riders, nor take joy only in the songs of slaying. I will be a healer, and love all things that grow and are

¹²¹ Letter 96 in Carpenter, *The Letters of J. R. R. Tolkien*, 111; quoted in Croft, *War and the Works of J. R. R. Tolkien*, 129.

¹²² Croft, *War and the Works of J. R. R. Tolkien*, 129–30.

¹²³ Candice Frederick and Sam McBride, *Women among the Inklings: Gender, C. S. Lewis, J. R. R. Tolkien, and Charles Williams* (London: Greenwood Press, 2001). See also Faye Ringel, “Women Fantasists: In the Shadow of the Ring,” in *J. R. R. Tolkien and His Literary Resonances: Views of Middle-Earth*, ed. George Clark and Daniel Timmons (Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 2000), 159–71.

not barren" (*The Lord of the Rings*, 943). As Frederick and McBride scathingly surmise, "Tolkien's choice for a would-be female warrior: submit to your allotted role as wife, or die."¹²⁴ The lack of agency for women in Middle-earth (when they appear at all) is not original to Tolkien. Éowyn's narrative arc embodies what Clare Simmons sees as a long-standing use for medievalism, one that she attributes partly to Edmund Burke, who "drew larger gender implications from the medieval than before, encouraging nostalgia for an age when women were not political beings, but treated with chivalric respect."¹²⁵ It is an impulse that elevates women to the point of adoration and at the same time strips them of agency, all in the name of chivalry, custom, or a general appeal to the past as validation of such practices.

As Tolkien scholarship has shown, the conservative representation of the Middle Ages through which Tolkien promotes particular constructions of gender in Middle-earth have been read as perpetuating other outmoded ideas, such as racial stereotypes and class structures.¹²⁶ Pointedly, Tolkien's Middle-earth constitutes a traditional form of medievalism that is rooted in the impulse that the Middle Ages were real and that they can be accurately recovered, understood, and incorporated properly into a Secondary World. By linking constructions of gender, race, and class to a world that is characterized by forms of medievalism rooted in the languages and culture of the European Middle Ages, Tolkien demonstrates the extent to which such constructions can be seemingly naturalized even in a work of fantasy. Portraying women as passive, heroes as hereditarily born to lead, and enemies as racially "other" thereby becomes part and parcel not only of Middle-earth, but also of the Middle Ages that Tolkien has reproduced.

As I demonstrate at length in the chapters that follow, the use of the Middle Ages to naturalize such constructions neither originated from, nor is limited to, Tolkien. Indeed, while rhetorically bent constructions

¹²⁴ Frederick and McBride, *Women among the Inklings*, 113.

¹²⁵ Simmons, *Medievalism and the Quest for the "Real" Middle Ages*, 5.

¹²⁶ See Brian McFadden's critique of Tolkien's portrayal of race in "Fear of Difference, Fear of Death: The *Sigelwara*, Tolkien's Swertings, and Racial Difference," in *Tolkien's Modern Middle Ages*, ed. Jane Chance and Alfred K. Siewers (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 155–69; Helen Young's reading of race in Middle-earth in *Race and Popular Fantasy Literature: Habits of Whiteness*; and Jane Chance's Foucauldian reading of power in Middle-earth in *The Lord of the Rings: The Mythology of Power* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 2001).

of the Middle Ages may have their roots in earlier forms of medievalism, they appear frequently in more recent forms of (neo)medievalism as well. Recognizing such rhetoric becomes all the more important in light of the fact that forms of medievalism can, as is the case with Tolkien's Middle-earth, become artifacts that are held up as forms of authority per se. Case in point: when Peter Jackson's 2001 film adaptation *The Fellowship of the Ring* dropped the character of Glorfindel and assigned some of his actions in the novel to the elf Arwen – a reconfiguration that recasts the beautiful and courtly but passive Arwen as an accomplished rider, tracker, and armed warrior – Jackson was heavily criticized for straying too far from the book.¹²⁷

While Tolkien's adherence to female passivity is one thing, using Tolkien to continually perpetuate such ideas is another thing entirely and, arguably, a move that contradicts the principles that make Tolkien's medievalism so powerful. Even with his vast knowledge of the Middle Ages, in order to create Middle-earth, Tolkien moved beyond the matter he inherited from the Middle Ages and from earlier forms of medievalism; if he had not, there would be no hobbits, no Quenya, no Gandalf. Likewise, Tolkien moved beyond the critical practices of his day to help shape the course of medieval studies; if he had not, it is likely that many an Anglo-Saxonist would have missed their calling. Above all, Tolkien exemplifies why we must insist on a critical assessment of the medievalisms (scholarly and otherwise) that we have inherited. He is a reminder that medievalism studies must be vigilant of the ways in which forms of medievalism establish relationships to the medieval and how these relationships are rhetorically employed.

¹²⁷ See Victoria Gaydosik "‘Crimes against the Book’? The Transformation of Tolkien's Arwen from Page to Screen and the Abandonment of the Psyche Archetype," in *Tolkien on Film: Essays on Peter Jackson's The Lord of the Rings*, ed. Janet Brennan (Altadena, CA: Mythopoeic, 2004), 215–30.